

The Unwinding Road

Parting the darkness of the torrential rains, a sole lightning bolt to reveal the contours of a castle looming large on the hill—the figure ahead, barely recognizable.

—“Miss Shi... Shirin? Is that you? Where are we?”

—“The Castle of Remembrance!”

—“Is that where we’re going?” The girl, you realize, is not Mariam—she is too young—but you nonetheless recognize her: it is Mariam’s friend Shirin. Only ten years younger. You have entered the realm of the Keeper of the Castle, and her name, as the master of the *dewān* had hinted, is indeed *shirin* [sweet].

—“Yes, come on,” as the sun parts the dark clouds—quite suddenly, but you shouldn’t be surprised anymore by the thespian magic of the local weather gods—you see her standing at the bottom of a staircase, “just a few steps.” She darts up the stairs, but somehow, each step you take makes you feel heavier and also less composed—literally. You look down. IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Your belly, it is swelling and your limbs, are they floating away?

—“Shirin, what is happening to me?” She stops and looks back at you and then laughs.

—“Ha, ha, that imminent, impatient imp is trying to get out precociously, prematurely, presumptively,” she lowers her head to your belly and whispers, “how are you going to tell the continuation of this grandiose, grotesque Gothic tale if you’re going to abandon your mommy’s memorable mind!” Who is she talking to?—it’s all so confusing—and the alliterations don’t help. But the swelling is all of sudden gone and your stars are again aligned—whatever that means.

—“Wha??”

—“Temporal displacements. Can be a nuisance. But they normally pass quickly. Oooh, I am so excited,” she magically opens a creaking gate—or, is it a magical gate swinging open with a creak—it is hard to tell how things work here—showing a big hall, empty but for a small red carpet in the middle, “Niiiiice! Come, Aryan princess, let’s sit on that carpet there—I apologize, my furniture doesn’t seem to have arrived yet. But the carpet, it’s nice no? We’ll fit.” You just nod and sit down next to her. It is a little cramped, so that your knees hit hers, which makes her giggle. She looks around and says.

—“Hmmm. I like it! Just as the Ambitious Architect had promised!” Wait. Is she implying that this is the first time she came inside?

—“But, Shirin, is this not your castle?”

—“It is. It will be. It was. But each time I want to enter, someone comes along and I have to guide them through their vision,” she puts her arms in her side, “It’s not fair you know. I am only eight!” Not knowing what to say, you congratulate her.

—“A very nice castle indeed. And one day, its halls will be filled with the laughter of your children.” She eagerly looks at you.

—“You think so?” Why did you say that? What do you know? But you don’t want to upset her and so you nod reassuringly.

—“And you will name your little girl Daughter of the Respected. And one day, she will be *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens].” Are you getting stark raving mad?! Where are you getting this from? Words just roll off your tongue, without thoughts guiding it.

—“Well, I guess, there is still a lot that has to happen, in books still to be written,” her face suddenly turns serious, “but one thing I know that’s going to happen and I need to talk to you about it.”

—“What is it?”

—“It is also a story in a book still to be written,” who is writing these books she is always referring to—as if we are all characters in a novel—there is a novel idea—an idea once formulated cannot be forgotten—forget not those memorable deeds—remembrance of the castle...—wow, wow, wow! Stop that crazy train in your head. Probably another one of those temporal misplacements in this distempered place. You have to regain control, and so you concentrate on Shirin’s cute little lips as she implores you, “But when it does, when the time has come, I beg you, oh Aryan princess, when that day comes that the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens] will seek Mariam and me out while we are hiding...”

—“From her, hiding from the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*?”

—“From her husband. But when that happens, you have to come too. With her. You must insist. Otherwise everything will be lost! She will never get to see her baby sister.”

—“Who? Why? Where? What??”

—“You’re asking a lot of questions, you know! I told you, I am only eight, so I don’t know that much. Only that you have to come. And *Patriarχis* Gregorios will be so happy to see you, and Lord Ioannis even more so. *Āy wāy*, and then poor Lord Yazdak! You have to come to his rescue! That’s all

I know, so don't ask me anything else!" What were all these people doing at that place she couldn't say where it was? Hiding from the *Shāhān-Shāh*?

—"I will try. But the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* might not want me to."

—"Why wouldn't she take her daughter-in-law with her?" Okay. And the confusion has started again. Even in the supernatural realm they don't seem to be able to tell you apart from Mariam. Just because of the red hair?!

—"Dear Shirin, I think you mistake me for my mistress, Mariam. The master of the *dewān* did so too. I am no princess!"

—"His dreams don't lie! But, princess or not, you have to promise me you will come," she looked really desperate, and she even added, in a pleading voice, "Please. I will even help you with your amorous quest, I promise!" What is that now supposed to mean? Trying to veer the topic of conversation away from you, you ask

—"Say, you're a princess too, no?" Or at least, bound to become one. For the rumors are that the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* wants her son Husrow to be engaged to Shirin. But the *Shāhān-Shāh* doesn't approve. But then everyone says that in the end, the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* will get her will. At least, if her mother-in-law doesn't stop her. Perhaps that's the reason. . . . No, you don't want to be drawn into their mad tale.

—"You think so?," the Keeper of the Castle, for being the guide to future events, seems to know surprisingly little about her own future. She whirls around, "You like my dress? But I am going to get a new one. A purple one. Like the empress! You saw the empress's purple dress, didn't you?" That one time when you watched the wedding parade of prince Germanus. But you only remember the purple one *Regia Mataswintha* wore that day.

—"I think so."

—"You know, the one with our Lord IESOUS on it, when he was a little baby! It's sooo pretty." You realize that she is actually confusing the Empress's dress with that of *Regia Mataswintha*, but she sounds so excited that you don't want to contradict her.

—"Indeed!"

—"And then Lady Mataswintha wore it," *pargast*, can she now read your mind too? She turns around and hugs you, "I am so glad you came! They never come for me, the others, you know. It's fun, but still. . ."

—"Say. How did you actually end up here?"

—"Alā, I was born in *Armin*, but that evil Suren—I think Anak was his

name—oh no, that was earlier, when my people still had to find *XRISTOS*—this zealot of a Suren was the one who denied us our faith, vile Chehr-Goshnāsp. So that accursed Suren, he oppressed our people and so the *naḵvadār*—those are the nobles of my country, like my father—they rebelled. But then the *Shāhān-Shāh* sent more troops and they ... they killed my daddy. But then Lady Gordiyag took pity on us and she brought us to Gondeshāpur, mommy and me. To help her friend Lady Kāren at the hospital,” you shouldn’t be surprised anymore by the irony that at this very moment, the real Shirin is actually retracing her steps to Gondeshāpur, to visit her godmother, Lady Kāren. And neither should you be by the involvement of Lady Gordiyag, for many noble deeds are told of her—she is awesome, “and she is the one who gave me this blue dress. But then mommy died. And that’s when I came here.” Is there then also a figment of you, after the passing of your own mommy, holding down some fort of the future? Probably not, especially because—sorry for having to repeat yourself—you are NO PRINCESS, *ballanbilaigonds*, *dungonitands*! (Pardon the lack of inhibition, but with all the twists you took and potions you drank...). Why are you now talking parenthetically? To regain focus onto the present—if that’s where/when you are—you ask

—“To guide the master of the *dewān* when he drinks the Queen’s potion?”

—“Oh, but he is not the only one. He likes it here, so, he comes here often. But no, there are many others who eat the figs and then come visit the realm of *shirin* [sweet] dreams.”

—“What do you mean? They eat the figs from the actual orchard in the Alwand valley? The *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*’s figs!”

—“Really? They are the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*’s? I thought the *Senmurw* said they were mine.”

—“The *Senmurw*?”

—“Yeah, my tutor, my instructor in the premonitory arts. Didn’t you know,” Lord Kawād has told you many stories about this mythical bird, the *Senmurw* [Simurg]—it’s basically like a phoenix, but Persian. And its touch can cure even the deadly wounded. And the girl is now its apprentice?, “Look up there. How gracious the flight of the *Senmurw*.”

*The great bird soared into the air
Its wings spread wide on the sunlit wind.*¹⁰⁴

¹⁰⁴Shāhnāmeḥ, Volume 1.

You look up—where did the roof of the castle all of a sudden go?—and you see indeed a golden ray of light floating through the sky. It seems to wave at you—can birds wave? And then it flies away.

—“Oh, he flies away. Where is he going?” She looks surprised at you.

—“For an Aryan princess, you’re quite ignorant, you know.”

—“Hey!”

—“All princesses know that a *Senmurw* is a female. Guardian of our Sisterhood. And now, my mistress is going to visit a young prince in Himyār—don’t ask me where that is.” Luckily, you know: Himyār, it is all the way in the south, a place the Romans call Arabia Felix [Yemen]. Probably not because it was visited by the *Senmurw*, ha, ha.

—“The prince, he is the Keeper of a Castle too?”

—“No, silly, he just lives in one, a very tall one—the tallest in the world they say. And my mistress visits him in his dreams. Oh, wait. That’s wrong. That has not happened yet. His grandfather has to die first, I think. And also, it’s the *Senmurw*’s sister who visits the boy—she once explained it to me, but is very confusing, about books that still have to be written and stories that still have to be told—all too confusing for an eight-year-old.” Age doesn’t have much to do with it. You are as baffled as Shirin. But you do know that a few years back, the *Shāhān-Shāh* had sent some of his fiercest warriors—Deylam they call them—to conquer Arabia Felix, and now they are its *Shāh* [kings]. So, this prince, he is a Deylam?

—“Why does the *Senmurw*, does her sister, visit the boy?”

—“So that he can tell his dreams to his little cousin—she needs to hear them to find her own purpose—and also to find her daddy. And the young prince also needs to tell it to that other boy—he is also from *Armin*, like me. But that boy first has to find his own princess, his own purpose. In that other book I was talking about.” Your head is getting quite dizzy from all the implied story lines. Your own, Gothic tale has already more than enough twists on its winding road to... to Well, good question. What was the purpose of this whole adventure? *Alā*, perhaps it is presumptuous to assume that adventures must have a point. Perhaps a tale should just be that, Gothic-slash-grotesque in all its glory, ha, ha. As if she reads your mind, Shirin, the Keeper of the Castle, jumps up. Her black eyes look suddenly so fiery. She is no ordinary eight-year-old!

—“But the tale must end now! Rewind we will,” and to your horror, she pulls out a vial from her pocket. It is the vial with the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*’s potion, “I believe you know what this is—you were not supposed

to, you know! Anyway, you have to take it!"

—"But... but it is poison. It will kill me."

—"When three drops taken, extinguished will be life's breath!"

—"I don't wanna," you whine, "Please, Shirin."

—"Alright. When one drop taken, extinguished will be life's fruit," you don't know what that means, but you don't want that either. Luckily, Shirin seems to agree, "but that would mess with the narration mode and the publishers are not going to like that." Ignoring the cockamamie gibberish, you hopefully ask:

—"So, I don't need to take it then?"

—"But when two drops taken, extinguished will be life's..." she hesitates a little, "well, I forgot now. But that's what you have to do. Two drops!"

—"I need to take two drops? And you don't even remember anymore what that will do to me!?"

—"I think that's the point," you don't know how the little girl all of a sudden manages to sit on top of you—did you not mention she is no ordinary eight-year-old?—, squeezing your nose closed with her left hand, so that you can but open your mouth to breathe, while the vial now starts to glow. Two green eyes flicker menacingly inside, each shedding a venomous drop which, very slowly—how is that possible?—fall into your open mouth. Bitter and yet *shirin* [sweet]... "goodbye, Aryan princess. It was nice to make your acquaintance. But now you must return to be a Gothic orphan."

You feel a ray of light shining upon you. It makes you open your eyes, but you have to blink several times to get used to the sun's brightness. There is still some rumbling in the distance, but the storm has gone. Or has it ever come? You lost all sense of time. You look around. You are back—or is it still?—in the small courtyard with the little pond. Some of the folios of Lord Ioannis's book have slipped from your lap, and you realize that you must have dozed off. Was this all a dream? A Gothic dream? There is one way to find out. You jump up to go ask the master of the *dewān*. But you cannot find its entrance. It has disappeared? Or, it was never there. What, *ballanbilaigonds*, *dunگونitands*, has just happened?!